certain kind of Hindu, can be an authentic Indian, is an affront to the very premise of Indian nationalism. An India that denies itself to some of us could end up being denied to all of us.

The reduction of non-Hindus to second-class status in their homeland is unthinkable. It would be a second Partition: and a partition in the Indian soul would be as bad as a partition in the Indian soil. But the roots of such thinking run deep in the ideology of Hindutva, and that is a cause for alarm for all concerned Hindus.

***

Hindutva (or as some would prefer to call it, *Sanghivad*—the beliefs and philosophy of the Sangh—to strip it of its religious connotations) is in many ways a distraction from the real issues facing the country: poverty and economic development, oppression and injustice, the evolution of our still-imperfect democracy. Identity politics becomes a diversion from the bread-and-butter (or dal-and-roti) issues that actually affect most Hindus. As discussed in Chapter Five, the Hindutva project involves an attempt to create an overarching political ideology that would subsume all the adherents of a highly differentiated and eclectic religious faith. Accordingly, the idea of Hindu nationalism conflates ideas of religion and culture with those of nation and state.

Nationalism is by definition indivisible, whereas religion and culture take on multiple manifestations. Culture, of course, contributes to national identity, yet culture alone cannot mould the nationalism of a country, let alone that of a plural land like India. In India during colonial rule, the reassertion of Indian culture was a nationalist project, which witnessed the revival of dance forms like Bharata Natyam and traditional classical music as well as modern literature in Indian languages, modern art (from Raja Ravi Varma to the Bengal School and painters like Husain who derived inspiration from the Indian epics) and what evolved into the gaudy cinema of Bollywood.

But an India confident in its own cultural diversity could celebrate multiple expressions of its culture. Hindutva sees culture differently; as Golwalkar wrote, culture ‘is but a product of our all-comprehensive religion, a part of its body and not distinguishable from it’. For Hindutva’s devotees, India’s national culture is Hindu religious culture,